FROM THE

# EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

In the run-up to the Uttar Pradesh election, it looked like the BJP had the upper hand in India's most populous state. There was the formidable 'double-engine' government of Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the Centre and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath in the state and the BJP's untiring electoral machinery. Moreover, the Opposition in the state was fragmented and listless after back-to-back defeats in the 2017 assembly election and the 2019 Lok Sabha poll.

The rise of Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav as Chief Minister Adityanath's principal opponent is therefore a recent phenomenon. It is also a remarkable one, given how the UP election looked like a multi-cornered contest between the BJP and the rest not so long ago. Now, Akhilesh Yadav has surged ahead of Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party and the Congress's Priyanka Gandhi.

Despite being one of only two state CMs to complete a full term, Akhilesh had a rocky stint as CM until 2017. His government was dogged by allegations of corruption and lawlessness. Powerful party satraps lent weight to the insinuation that the state was being run by 'four-and-a-half CMs'. Akhilesh was finally voted out of power five years ago in a wave election built on popular discontent and public support for Prime Minister Modi's demonetisation drive. The SP's tally of 47 seats was the lowest since its inception in 1992. In the absence of a similar wave this year, the only movement in UP seems to be undercurrents. And that is what makes Akhilesh's strategy interesting to watch. For starters, he seems to have borrowed from the BJP's playbook of putting together a rainbow coalition of the sort they fielded against him in 2017—non-Yadav OBCs and non-Jatav Scheduled Castes.




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The BJP got 40 per cent of the vote share in 2017. The SP's game plan is to cobble together a coalition to get to this figure—using the same elements. It is a daunting task, given that the party garnered only 21.8 per cent of the vote in the preceding assembly election. Not only does Akhilesh face the challenge of closing the gap but also of crossing it. With this in mind and lessons from past experience, he has chosen to steer clear of tie-ups with the Congress or the BSP.

Akhilesh has also broad-based ticket distribution to move away from his core Muslim-Yadav vote base and give more seats to others. For instance, almost 27 per cent of the tickets have been given to non-Yadav OBCs. The SP scion has reached out to smaller castes like the Mauryas, Sainis and Patels, and accommodated defecting ministers from the Yogi government, each a prominent representative of one of these castes. There have been overtures to the Dalits and a tie-up with Jayant Chaudhary's RLD (Rashtriya Lok Dal), which represents the Jats of western UP. Assurances like 33 per cent reservations for women in government jobs and a special task force ensuring their safety if his party is voted to power are meant to woo the female electorate.

Caste, though, is rarely mentioned upfront. Akhilesh has instead focused on aspirational issues like development and jobs. He has promised government jobs and free laptops to the youth, and free power to farmers. Also highlighted are issues like inflation and Covid mismanagement, even as he speaks of the positives in his tenure. Whatever the outcome, this election has seen the birth of a shrewd young politician who has smoothly taken over the family-run party.

The BJP regime's biggest strength in UP is that it has been able to deliver rations to the people two times a month. The ruling party's biggest drawback is what is perceived as its failure to honour its commitment to farmers. The fact that stray cattle are trampling farmers' fields is a major sore point with the agricultural community. Timely payments of the minimum support price for sugarcane is another bugbear.

Chief Minister Adityanath is seen as incorruptible, but there is a strange disconnect between him and partymen miffed at not being allowed to share the spoils of power. The party is counting on the impressive appeal of the Modi-Yogi combination to see it through to a majority.

If Akhilesh does pull off an upset on March 10, it will radically alter the political dynamics within the country and reset equations within the Opposition.

Our story, 'The Challenger', written by Group Editorial Director (Publishing) Raj Chengappa with inputs from Special Correspondent Prashant Srivastava in Lucknow, looks at how the SP chief turned the corner in UP. Chengappa and Group Photo Editor Bandeep Singh accompanied both Akhilesh and Chief Minister Adityanath on their respective campaign trails. This promises to be one nail-biter of a finish. Making it one has been Akhilesh Yadav's biggest achievement so far.

*(Aroon Purie)*